

Epicure Cup Specials

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THE AGE
MELBOURNE LIVING

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Picture: SANDY EDWARDS

Godfather
of the
Hunter

In the first of three profiles on key figures in the Australian wine industry, RICHARD YALLOP went to the Hunter Valley to meet the champion of the "old school".

MASTERS
OF WINE

breakfast at the old wooden winery at Pokolbin, when Tyrrell, the head of the dynasty, sits at the end of the table and goes round the staff one by one asking them what they are doing, and why.

Eggs and bacon, toast and tea, are served by women in pale blue nylon tunics. Staff members speak when they are spoken to.

Tyrrell had already landed a few verbal cuffs around the ear when he decided the tea tasted rotten. "Woolworths' tea," he barked. "Fancy drinking this at Tyrrell's."

The tea ladies smiled and duly brought in a new pot.

Tyrrell, 63 this year, is proudly old school, with an appearance to match. His strong features and greased-back hair and parting are a reminder of the '50s, and a past

era. Television and American culture had not arrived and people were closer to the land. They had solid values, wore double-breasted suits, and thought like Bill Hunter as the "old school" cameraman in 'Newsfront' who believed in his way of doing things.

Tyrrell is a part of all that. In the Second World War he went through New Guinea and the Pacific with the Armored Regiment, and now he directs most of his charitable giving to the Salvation Army, "because they were the ones who supported us in the front line." The Tyrrell family also used to sponsor the local Church of England boys' home at Cessnock, which has long since gone.

Murray Tyrrell was born into a wine-making family. Grandfather Edward planted the first vines at

Pokolbin in 1858, and Murray's father Avery kept the business going with Uncle Dan. It was part of Tyrrell family mythology that Dan did 75 consecutive vintages from 1884 to 1959.

Young Murray was a boarder at Maitland High School, and after school (where he was an outstanding cricketer, scoring a hundred for NSW Schoolboys, opening with Arthur Morris) he became a jackaroo at Queanbeyan. He will tell you his first love is animals — the dogs, who never leave him, the horses, which he rides most days, and his 1000 cattle.

The locals say Tyrrell's 1400-hectare holding makes him a paper millionaire. He is more worried about the trendy balloonists who have started flying over the Hunter. "I carry a gun around threatening to shoot them," he said. "It's the only way to get rid of them. They worry my cattle."

Said a friend: "Murray is one of the old-style Australians. He rounds up his cattle and calls a spade a spade."

Tyrrell brings much the same approach to his staff breakfasts at the winery. "Ryddo," he said brisly as each man finished his say, and he moved on to the next, rather like a schoolmaster conducting a test in a class of quaking schoolboys. (He was a gunner in the war and some would say he has

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kept on firing long after the cessation of hostilities.)

Last Friday he was in a rush because he had an appointment in Sydney with the Minister for Agriculture and he had to catch the early morning flight from Cessnock. "C'mon, Roy," he said to one of the old retainers, "I want to drive to the airport." Roy smartened his pace, and they boarded the jag and disappeared down the drive.

The staff were now at ease in the breakfast room. No, no one admitted to being scared of the boss. He had mellowed, they said. And if anyone had a problem, he would go out of his way to help. One of the women had been sick and he insisted she stay home for another week. Someone else said he was a "sweetie" deep-down.

One of the junior wine makers remembered the day the boss had grabbed him by the ear and pulled him down to the winery to show him the vinegar escaping from one of the wine casks. Tyrrell had gone in as usual at seven that morning and put his nose to the air, like the country animal he is, and picked up the smell of the oxidised wine. He always knew exactly what was going on in the winery.

He also seems to know exactly what goes on in the Hunter, and every hectare of land in the valley. He fought at the public hearings, with great outpourings of emotion, to stop the aluminium smelters from discharging their fluoride on the vines. Others, such as Murray Robson, proprietor of the Mount View vineyard, also spoke against the smelters, using logic and rationality, but Murray Tyrrell spoke from the gut. That fight was won, and now there is a new one, to preserve the valley from the threat of subdivision.

Murray Tyrrell, Godfather of the Hunter, as we discovered on our visit. The arrangement had been made that photographer Sandy Edwards and I would be at the winery at 8 am on the Friday. But at each unannounced Hunter stop we made the previous evening, at Peppers Guest House, and the Casuarina Restaurant, there were messages from Mr Tyrrell. He seemed to have eyes and ears all over the valley.

We had been sitting down for 15 minutes in the Casuarina when he appeared out of the kitchen and sat down at our table. He was very sorry but he had to go early to Sydney to see the Minister, so could we go earlier to take the pictures? He chatted for 10 minutes, then left, to be followed shortly by the waitress appearing with the Tyrrell's 1976 pinot noir that won the Gault-Millau trophy in Paris. "Compliments of Mr Tyrrell," she said.

That win helped bring pinot noir to Australia's attention, just as Tyrrell was really the first man to popularise the chardonnay grape in Australia. Some say that it was his pioneering with those two varieties that will be remembered as his most significant contribution to Australian wine. He says he was also the first to use pinot noir in champagne, and to make a cabernet-merlot blend. Old school he may be, but he does not lack foresight or commercial acumen.

When he took over from Uncle Dan in 1959 Tyrrell's was doing little more than producing bulk wine for companies like McWilliams. It has now reached the point of selling 150,000 cases a year, cleverly straddling both the premium table wine and commer-



Murray Tyrrell, at the head of the table, questions staff members one by one at his winery's weekly staff breakfast.

cial sectors of the market. In the latter, sales of Tyrrell's Long Flat Red have risen from 20,000 to 80,000 a year. He has been accused of dishonest labelling with the Long Flat Red, part of which comes from other states, but he doesn't care. He puts the criticism down to the tall poppy syndrome. "I've survived and others haven't. If there's enough Hunter in the blend, I couldn't care where the rest comes from, Brazil, wherever, so long as the public like it. We must have wines like that so people can have everyday drinking."

The one blemish in Tyrrell's business record is that many years ago he was declared bankrupt after a failed involvement in a cattle-exporting business. The skeleton is still sometimes shaken in the Hunter.

"It amazes me people want to talk about that," said Tyrrell, when reminded. "Bloody jealousies, they're the curse of this country. We always knock the one who succeeds. I don't deny I was declared bankrupt. I was discharged within 18 months."

On a recent promotional trip to Melbourne, Tyrrell, standing in the lobby of Rockman's Regency in his immaculate grey suit, looked anything but the man from the bush. This was the same Murray Tyrrell whose friends include former Prime Minister Malcolm Fraser, and former Liberal minister Tony Street, both wine buffs. He can lobby when he has to.

"Fraser loved old semillons. That's what first brought him to the Hunter. And like me, he loved

chardonnay and pinot noir. The greatest wine I've ever found was the '62 La Tache. I've drunk it everywhere in the world I could find it."

Tyrrell said his love of burgundy stemmed from the '80s when he and Len Evans used to consume large amounts. "I thought, 'Why can't I grow them?'" In fact Penfold's had some chardonnay grapes at their Hunter Valley Distillery vineyard, and Tyrrell took some cuttings, planting them in 1969.

"In 1973 it won all the shows, and from then on everybody started planting it. The '76 and '77 were fantastic. But I don't think it's the great liver we thought. They're not going on in bottle like I thought they would."

Tyrrell's Vat 47 chardonnay has since become a collector's item, and the most recent, the '85, has just won the McMahon Trophy for the best full-bodied, dry white at the Adelaide Show.

Tyrrell took his pinot noir cuttings from McWilliams, and he made his first vintage in 1972. The Gault-Millau trophy winner, the '76 — big, rich, and velvety — is quite different from the lighter-bodied and well-praised '84. Tyrrell said of the '84: "It's light, full of fruit, and soft, and in this climate that's the sort of wine you can drink."

In fact it has the kind of finesse that has come to be associated with "cool climate" wines, but

then Tyrrell says that is a load of rot. "Bring out your great cool climate wine, and I'll show you two from the Hunter. Where are they? I want to see them."

"The real problem is not climate, but cool storage. That August-September growing period in Burgundy can be stinking hot, but there aren't too many nights that you can't sleep in the Hunter. I think it is the best area in Australia for growing burgundy-style wine. Anyone who thought they could grow riesling or cabernet must be mad."

That brings us back to the great debate: "old" versus "new" wine making techniques, and the Tyrrell-Croser argument. "We've got one of the best labs in the Hunter," said Tyrrell. "The debate is only how far do you go with science? There was a big change in world wine making and a shift to the scientific in the mid '70s, and we thought we'd better follow. But it didn't work in the Hunter."

Tyrrell has tried cold fermentation of white wines in refrigerated tanks, and rejected it in favor of "cool" fermentation; he has tried and rejected fermentation with single, foreign yeasts, like the R2 yeast popularised by Croser, in favor of fermentation by the natural yeasts produced by the grapes; and in red wine he has rejected fermentation in stainless steel containers in favor of the traditional open vats.

"We've done tests in different

wineries using stainless steel fermenters and open vats and by far the best wines were made in the open vats at home. And that's not because it was the best fruit. In the open vats we achieved better color, and softer, cleaner wines with less hydrogen sulphide.

"I think Brian Croser revolutionised the bottom-to-middle end of the market, making much cleaner wines, through filtration, and by capturing the flavors of the grapes. But he lacks the complexity in aged wines. I believe he's become over-technical." (Croser will reply next week.)

Tyrrell said there was an arrogance about both him and Croser, a sense that they had a monopoly of knowledge on how to make wine. "People say I go on about this, but it's not to counter the young men; it's to stimulate them, and make them think. I get up and speak my mind and so does Brian. He's only a boy, I've been in it 30 years longer. I'm the first to admire what he's done, but I'm not going to change because I think I'm right. I've succeeded."

"I think I'm making wine that is just as good without all that equipment and expense. No one can make great wines without the grapes. What about all those great Lindeman's wines of the '60s. How did they make those? I'll go my way and Brian can go his."

"I think instinct is a great thing in wine making. When you're

Continued Living 2

Ranking auctions on a misery scale

EXTRAORDINARY things happen in Melbourne as soon as the football is over.

● Eleven out of 12 coaches are taken away and shot.

● Back lawns get mowed for the first time in seven months.

● The auction season starts and four out of five people move house.

We have just moved again. On a scale of human misery, rape and murder rank No. 1, armed robbery No. 2, losing your spouse No. 3. Having your house auctioned is No. 4, and maybe losing your luggage on Qantas is No. 5. Locking your keys in the car is No. 6.

The real estate men told us the house would have to be on show for six weeks. There would be two public viewing times a week and other buyers would come through by appointment.

We had lived in our street for eight years, and maybe we had met five per cent of the residents. Come auction time we met them all. Some went through our house three times.

The worst part was keeping the place in show condition for six weeks. There's no greater hell. I have always believed bedroom seats are for hanging trousers on and diningroom tables are instruments for supporting outspread newspapers. Beds are devices for covering assorted shoes.



"You realise that when they go through the house they look in all your cupboards," said my wife. "You aren't honestly going to leave your singlets and underpants like that. What will people think?"

So I had to stack my singlets like a display cupboard at David Jones. Even worse, the carpet had to be vacuumed every morning. "I don't want you to go in the living-room, you'll disturb something. You'd better stay in the kitchen."

I tell you, for six weeks the place was like the British Museum at opening time. Heads were constantly popping up over the garden wall, noses would appear against the window.

Then the morning after we decided to sell, come 6 am: "BANG! BANG!" It was an enormous board

going up outside. In the dim early light we read the beautiful prose. It made our house sound like the type of noble establishment in which the former Governor, Sir Brian Murray, must have wished he had lived.

"This most beautiful Victorian residence, superbly renovated throughout to perfectly blend with all the outstanding character of its era."

It mentioned that parking was provided. It was, too. You could get a council permit to park in the street.

This board was so inspiring we have become students of estate prose, and in my retirement I hope to set up business as a board writer.

Here is a glossary of terms: "Excellent home for young marrieds or investment." Translation: Two days' camel ride in a suburb even the map makers do not know about.

"Renovator's dream." Translation: A nightmare actually. Don't lean against the weatherboards, you might fall through.

"Ideal purchase for imaginative buyer." Ideal to use your imagination to overcome the view of the tip.

"Character and charm with high ceilings." Translation: "There's a colony of possums in the high ceiling but the real char-

acter and charm comes with the dunny out the back."

"This home superb for decorating to your own individual taste." Translation: Owned until last week by a 90-year-old widow. Nothing has been done to it since 1908. Even the National Trust would be frightened of the chip bath heater.

It is interesting to interpret language. "Delightful bush setting" means bloody miles from town. "Charming," "quaint," means it has seen better days. "Outstanding modern environment" means it is absolutely surrounded by flats. "Interesting and unusual environment" means that the current owner's taste is nigh beyond belief. "Breathtaking views" means that when the southerly blows you get the full smell from the oil refinery.

There is no experience as unnerving as the auction day itself. A vast crowd gathers. Some turn up in Mercedes, BMWs, Volvos, and you think you cannot go wrong. The entire street arrives with their dogs. Some are in shorts and thongs.

The auctioneer gathers them all together and gives an opening address. I doubt if King Harry at Agincourt, Abe Lincoln at Gettysburg or even Churchill on the eve of the Battle of Britain were more eloquent.

"Why are we selling?" said my wife. "This place is so wonderful, we must be out of our minds."

But all those people are only there to look. Ultimately there are only one or two bidders. Finally, with a sick feeling in your stomach, a deal is done with last-minute haggling.

And the hardest part comes later. It is a curious thing; you never actually leave a house. A part of you stays there forever. I can remember the precise layout, almost every floorboard of every house I have ever lived in. I wander through those houses in my dreams.

Oh yes, Midge the cori was buried over here, Sam the Siamese was interred there. That's the window we mended at least 15 times playing cricket. And, my God, those gutters, you could reach them with the paint brush on the 12-ft. ladder, teetering at full stretch.

And there in the bedroom is the personal exit and entrance for Bessie the poodle. She has been in and out there at least 2,400,000 times. What will she do at the next place?

Every morning a little fat willy wagtail would dance by the pool and say, "Hello", and the silver-eyes would bathe in the bird bath. I hope the newcomers are kind to Willy.

— Keith Dunstan

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Guzzini Cutlery Tray
(red or white) \$9.50

House.

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